

Chapter 108-3

Seeing Liang Wanwan treat the sketchbook on that sticky note so carefully, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu exchanged a glance and saw helplessness in each other's eyes.

This was something that simply couldn't be restored.

However, seeing how sad Liang Wanwan was, Liang Shi tentatively said: "How about I contact Chen Mian again and have her draw you another one?"

She had expected Liang Wanwan to agree without hesitation, but Liang Wanwan shook her head. "No, thank you."

She refused so quickly that Liang Shi thought she had misheard.

She couldn't help but confirm: "What?"

"There's no need." Liang Wanwan said: "Even if I got another one, it wouldn't have any meaning."

It was this sketchbook that had accompanied her through her youth, and also through those difficult days when she was preparing for the art college entrance exam.

And many sleepless nights spent missing Chen Mian.

Now that this sketchbook was gone, it also meant her youth should come to an end.

This secret crush should draw to a close.

Originally, she had intended to end this silent crush, which was why she had asked Liang Shi to request this favor from Chen Mian.

But what she got in return was an even longer attachment and a deeper bond.

Liang Wanwan lowered her eyes, her voice sorrowful. "Thank you, Jie."

She gazed at the sketchbook that was now unrecognizable, let out a deep breath, and said to Liang Shi: "Jie, I've disturbed you tonight. I'll just stay here for one day and go back to school tomorrow. You don't need to worry about me."

"Then what are you afraid of?" Xu Qingzhu suddenly asked her. "You still haven't talked about what you mentioned earlier."

When Liang Wanwan heard this question, her body stiffened for a moment. She said quietly: "Forget it."

"How can we just forget it?" Liang Shi frowned. "You slapped Liang Xinran—haven't you received any phone calls?"

"Yes." Liang Wanwan pressed her lips together and looked up at Liang Shi. "I have two phone numbers. I turned off one of them."

The other number was from a SIM card issued by the school for connecting to the dormitory network. Qiu Zimin didn't know about it.

Fear and timidity were still evident in Liang Wanwan's eyes.

Looking at her, Liang Shi suddenly understood a phrase—timid yet defiant.¹

The seemingly most inconspicuous Liang Wanwan was the first person in that family to slap Liang Xinran.

Although she was afraid of Qiu Zimin, she had still secretly gotten two phone numbers while appearing compliant on the surface.

Liang Shi thought for a moment. "Have you thought about what to do afterward?"

Liang Wanwan bit her lip. "I'll go back to school. Mom can't possibly come make a scene at our school, right? Besides, we're going to another province next week. If she can't find me, she won't do anything... right?"

Liang Wanwan was soft-hearted after all. After pausing for a moment, she said: "I don't know if what I did was right or wrong either. Mom feels especially guilty toward her, and she seems to have good intentions too. It's like she got scared after driving away Da-ge and Er-ge, so she's trying to please me, but..."

Liang Shi listened quietly as she spoke.

Liang Wanwan held the cup of ginger sugar water that was still steaming, her palms wrapped around the cup for warmth. She murmured softly: "I just can't bring myself to like her."

Liang Shi asked: "Why?"

Liang Wanwan took a sip of water. The hot water traveled from her mouth through her throat and all the way to her stomach, and she felt warmth throughout her entire body.

After a long while, she slowly said: "I feel like she's always acting weak, but her weakness has hurt a lot of people. I only found out after I came home that Er-ge had also moved out, and Mom is bedridden. The whole family feels so exhausted. What I did seems like..."

"There's no 'seems like.'" Liang Shi said: "Your feelings are probably right."

Liang Shi didn't say too much more. She just let her go check Liang Xinran's Weibo herself.

The original ID was still "Girl Searching for Family Guo Xinran," but it had now been changed to @Liang Xinran.

The bio read: Thank you to everyone. I have returned to my biological parents' side.

Her pinned post had also been changed to a long list of thank-you messages.

Probably for the traffic, she hadn't deleted any of her original Weibo posts. You could see all the content by clicking into them.

After reading through it, Liang Wanwan was puzzled: "She has so many followers. How could she have no money? Based on the level of follower monetization, her monthly income should be at least ten thousand yuan."

"Exactly." Liang Shi said: "And the content of her Weibo posts is so meticulous that it doesn't seem like she wrote them herself at all."

Liang Wanwan's fingers swiped across the screen a few times. "I didn't know what her background was. I actually wanted to get along with her normally."

For Liang Wanwan, getting along normally just meant occasionally having a few meals together. Since she was preparing her graduate school application for studying abroad and would probably spend the next several years overseas, she didn't really care who came to live in the family home.

After all, she was just an invisible person in that house anyway.

But she never expected that this person had only been there for a week and had already turned the whole family upside down.

Liang Wanwan looked at her previously pinned Weibo post. The more she looked at it, the more familiar the writing style seemed.

She switched the app to WeChat and searched for a public account.

This was one her roommate had recommended she follow before, calling it "million-view copywriting" and "rhythm master."² Her roommates were all people who loved eating melons,³ always at the forefront of internet surfing, while she tended to be a beat slower than everyone else.

Because she had really liked Yang Shuyan for a while, she had followed this public account under her roommates' guidance, since it had published several articles related to Yang Shuyan.

After opening it, Liang Wanwan casually clicked on an article about some celebrity in the entertainment industry.

This person had a formatting habit—they particularly liked using enumeration commas,⁴ and also liked using "的" (de) and "了" (le).⁵

These two characters appeared especially frequently in their articles, often showing up in places where they weren't necessary. It would seem somewhat abrupt, yet it didn't affect readability. After reading more, you would even feel that their writing was smooth and fluent.

1. "又慫又剛" (yòu sǒng yòu gāng) literally means "both cowardly and tough"—describing someone who appears timid but actually has a stubborn, defiant side. ⇐
2. "節奏大師" (rhythm master) in Chinese internet slang refers to someone who is skilled at manipulating public opinion or "controlling the narrative/rhythm" of online discussions, often by writing viral content that stirs up controversy. ⇐
3. "吃瓜" (chī guā, literally "eating melons") is Chinese internet slang for watching drama unfold or being a spectator to gossip, similar to "watching the tea" or enjoying drama from the sidelines. ⇐
4. The enumeration comma "、" (dùn hào) is a punctuation mark unique to Chinese used to separate items in a list, similar to how commas separate list items in English. ⇐
5. "的" (de) and "了" (le) are extremely common grammatical particles in Chinese. "的" is a possessive/attributive particle, while "了" indicates completed action or change of state. Overusing them is a distinctive writing quirk that can make text identifiable. ⇐